

Acknowledgments {-}

I hope this book was worth your time.

I started writing because I thought I had ideas about AI. I finished realizing the book was really about teams. It was, along the way, a kind of self-reflection: an accounting of where I took the easy route, and where I should have been more dedicated to the team than to myself.

A lot of books in this genre can sound like utopian dreams. Extreme Programming showed us what collaboration could look like, and much of it was applied, just never all of it, and rarely in the same way twice. This book will meet the same fate. That is fine. If you found something useful here, or even just enjoyed the anecdotes, then it did what it needed to do.

This book stands on older shoulders. Kent Beck and the XP community made the diagnosis long before agents existed. Woody Zuill and Llewellyn Falco showed what a whole team thinking together looks like in practice. I have only moved their furniture into a new house.

My thanks also go to the first readers, from the earliest drafts to the more refined ones. Matthias asked “why do I need the team?” and refused to accept my first three answers. The book is sharper because he kept refusing. Kaushal gave me the insight that implementation was never just a bottleneck, but the medium through which knowledge traveled; half of the Alexandria Problem grew from that sentence. Johann read for the readers I would otherwise have forgotten. And to everyone else who gave me their evenings and their honest comments: thank you. Where the book is right, they helped. Where it is wrong, that is mine alone.

Thank you to my family, who lost me to this manuscript on more weekends than I want to count.

AI agents helped me edit, structure, and stress-test these pages. The mistakes, like the ideas, are mine. I tried to stay left of my own loop.

One more thing, because the pages ahead will age: the tools in this book will be renamed or replaced before its ideas are. Teams outlast tooling. That is the bet underneath every chapter, and the safest one in the book.

Now take the pieces that matter to you and try them. Share what you find, tell me where I am

wrong at leftoftheloop.dev, and do not let the tool define how you work.